(1953), Thailand (1954), and Japan (1960). The key to China's challenge to American primacy, however, is the more ambiguously situated island of Taiwan, which lies in the middle of what Chinese strategists call the "first island chain" between China and the Pacific Ocean. (The first island chain extends from the Kamchatka Peninsula to the Malay Peninsula and encompasses the Kuril Islands, Japan, the Ryukyu Islands, Taiwan, the northern Philippines, and Borneo.)

The Taiwan Relations Act of April 10, 1979, states that America will "consider any effort to determine the future of Taiwan by other than peaceful means, including by boycotts or embargoes, a threat to the peace and security of the Western Pacific area and of grave concern to the United States" and that America "will make available to Taiwan such defense articles and defense services in such quantity as may be necessary to enable Taiwan to maintain a sufficient self-defense capability."

Since Trump's election, the United States has been underlining its commitment to Taiwan in a variety of ways—for example, the Asia Reassurance Initiative Act of 2018. The Taiwan Assurance Act, passed unanimously by the US House of Representatives in May 2019, urges the United States not only to continue selling arms to Taiwan but also to support Taiwan's participation in international organizations (in other words, to resist Beijing's efforts to freeze Taiwan out of all such organizations). (At the time of writing, January 2020, the bill has yet to be put before the Senate.) In 2019 Washington authorized two major arms sales to Taiwan: M1 Abrams tanks and F-16 Viper jets.

This flies in the face of the Chinese government's ambition to integrate Taiwan into the People's Republic of China (PRC), ending its de facto autonomy. As a recent report from the Australian Lowy Institute put it:

> For Xi's China, annexing Taiwan is core to achieving national redemption and the "Chinese dream"—Xi's agenda for "the great rejuvenation of the Chinese nation in the new era." In theory,